City of Boulder
Fire Department
Community Risk Reduction
2967 BLUFF ST. BOULDER, CO 80301
LIEUTENANT CODY ELMORE (303) 441-3350

MOBILE FOOD VEHICLE FIRE INSPECTION & SAFETY INFORMATION

Overview

- **Purpose:** Boulder Fire Rescue requires a fire inspection for all Mobile food Vehicles (MFV) operating within the city limits to ensure compliance with the 2024 International Fire Code, focusing on fuel safety and related aspects.

Inspection Process

- **Location:** Inspections are conducted at the Boulder Fire Administration building located at 2967 Bluff St. Boulder, CO 80301
- **Application:** A completed mobile food vehicle inspection application must be typed and emailed to foodtruckinspection@bouldercolorado.gov.
- **Scheduling:** Once the application is received, the applicant will be contacted to schedule an inspection appointment. Inspections occur on Wednesdays, excluding all holidays.
- **On Arrival:** It is important to park in the designated area, as indicated on the map provided. A fire inspector will meet the applicant to begin the inspection.
- **Outcome:**
    - **Pass:** The owner receives a copy of the Inspection Report and a Certificate of Inspection via e-mail. These documents are needed to obtain a business license from the City of Boulder.
    - **Fail:** The owner receives a detailed report of violations and has thirty (30) days to correct them before a reinspection can be scheduled.

Inspection with Violations

- **Reinspection Required:** If violations are found, the business has thirty (30) days to correct them and must schedule a reinspection.
- **Non-Compliance:** Failure to pass the reinspection will result in no Fire Marshals Association of Colorado (FMAC) Certificate of Inspection being issued, and the City of Boulder Licensing Division will be notified.

FMAC Certificate of Inspection

- **Issuance:** This certificate is issued once the MFV passes the fire inspection.
- **Requirements:** The application information must be accurate as it will appear as such on the certificate.
- **Availability:** The issued certificate must always be kept on the vehicle and available for inspection. If not, the business will be asked to stop operations, and the City of Boulder Licensing Division will be notified.

Liquid Propane Gas (LPG) Cylinders

Usage and Safety Parameters

- **Capacity:** the maximum aggregate water capacity for propane bottles is 50 gallons, equivalent to approximately two 100-pound propane bottles.
- **Shut-off Valves:**
  - **Labeling:** Shut-off valves for LPG cylinders or manifold systems must be clearly marked with a sign reading "Propane Shut Off Valve."
  - **Sign Specifications:** Signs must have a minimum of two-inch red lettering on a white background and be visible to the public.
- **Transportation and Installation:**
  - **Securing Cylinders:** LPG cylinders must be secured during transport and isolated from interior or passenger areas.
  - **Location:** Cylinders should be kept away from open flames and heat sources such as generators.
  - **Mounting:** ASME cylinders are generally mounted externally, with appliances piped outside the passenger/work area. Portable cylinders must be isolated from passenger areas, either secured or mounted outside or placed in a gas-tight compartment.
- **Leak Prevention:**
  - **Gas-Tight Systems:** All piping, tubing, pressure regulators, and valves must be gas-tight to prevent leakage.
  - **Inspection/Maintenance Program:** Regular inspections and maintenance are required to prevent leaks.
- **Safety Signage:**
  - **No Smoking Signs:** Signs must be posted next to or directly above propane containers, visible to the public, with a minimum two-inch red lettering on a white background.

Type I Commercial Hood System

Cooking Equipment Safety

- **Fire Suppression System:**
  - **Requirement:** A Type I Commercial Hood System is required for all cooking operations that produce grease-laden vapors.
  - **Activation:** Systems can be activated automatically or manually to suppress flames and will automatically shut down the fuel or electric supply to the cooking equipment.
- **Inspection:**
  - **Frequency:** Fire suppression systems must be inspected every six (6) months by a licensed contractor.
  - **Documentation:** The contractor must attach an inspection tag to the system and send a copy of the inspection report to Boulder Fire Rescue.
  - **Compliance:** If the report is not received in a timely manner, the MFV business may be contacted and required to stop operations until compliance is achieved.
- **Violation Correction:**
  - **Timeframe:** Any violations noted during the inspection must be corrected within thirty (30) days.
  - **Reinspection:** A licensed contractor must send a report showing code compliance after corrections.

Portable Fire Extinguishers

Requirements and Placement

- **Equipment Requirement:**
  - **Rating:** All MFV's must be equipped with at least one 2A:20-BC rated fire extinguisher.
  - **Condition:** The fire extinguisher must be fully charged and inspected annually by a licensed contractor.
- **Placement:**
  - **Proximity:** The fire extinguisher must be mounted within thirty (30) feet of commercial cooking equipment, secured on a hanger, and in clear view.
- **Additional Requirements for Grease-laden Vapors:**
  - **Class K Portable Fire Extinguisher:** MFV's with cooking operations producing grease-laden vapors must have an additional 1.5-gallon Class K portable fire extinguisher. All solid fuel cooking operations (wood burning stoves) producing grease-laden vapors, must have an additional 2.0-gallon in replace of the 1.5-gallon Class K portable fire extinguisher.

Personal Training

- **Training:** Personnel must be properly trained in the use of portable fire extinguishers to ensure effective manual fire suppression in the event of a fire.
  The guidelines ensure the safety of operators and customers while maintaining compliance with the 2024 International Fire Code. Proper adherence to these standards helps minimize the risk of fire and enhances the overall safety of the MFV industry.

Detection Devices

Carbon Monoxide (CO) Detectors

- **Hazard:** Carbon monoxide (CO) is a deadly, colorless, orderless gas produced by the incomplete burning of fuels such as coal, wood, charcoal, oil, kerosene, propane, and natural gas.
- **Sources:** CO is also produced by internal combustion engines like those in portable generators, cars, lawn mowers, and power washers.
- **Detection:**
  - **CO Detectors:** Install CO detectors to provide early warning of this deadly gas.
  - **Note:** CO detectors are not a substitute for the proper use and maintenance of appliances that can produce Co.

Propane and Natural Gas Detectors

- **Hazard:** Leaks of propane and natural gas can lead to explosive fires if the gas finds an ignition source.
- **Detection:**
  - **Gas Detectors:** Install propane or natural gas detectors to monitor gas levels at the sensors.
  - **Alarm Threshold:** Devices should be set to alarm at less than 25% of the lower explosive levels (LOL) of natural gas or propane.
  - **Note:** Detectors do not replace the need for regular maintenance of piping, tubing, pressure regulators, and valves.

Staff Training

Fire Extinguisher Use

- **Fire Extinguisher Operation:** Use the acronym **PAST** to remember how to use a fire extinguisher:
  - **P**ull out the pin.
  - **A**im at the base of the fire.
  - **S**weep at the base of the fire in a sweeping motion.
  - **T**en feet away: maintain a safe distance of about 10 feet from the fire.

Fire Prevention Practices

- **Grease Management:**
  - **Cleaning:** Regularly clean exhaust hoods to prevent grease buildup, which can restrict air flow and increase fire risk.
  - **Areas to Clean:** Clean walls, work surfaces, ranges, fryers, broilers, grills, convection ovens, vents, and filters.
- **Handling Grease Fires:**
  - **No Water:** Never throw water on a grease fire, as it may cause the grease to splatter and spread the fire.
  - **Use Correct Extinguishers:** Use Class K fire extinguishers specifically designed for grease fires.
  - **Ash Removal:** Remove ashes from wood and charcoal burning ovens at least once a day to reduce fire risk.
- **Storage of Flammable Liquids:**
  - **Containers:** Keep flammable liquids in their original or puncture-resistant, tightly sealed containers, clearly labeled.
  - **Storage:** Store containers in well-ventilated areas, away from combustibles, food, preparation areas, and heat sources.
- **Fire Hazard Mitigation:**
  - **Tidy Environment:** Store products, linens, boxes, and food away from heat and cooking sources.
  - **Disposal:** Dispose of soiled rags, trash, cardboard, boxes, and wooden pallets at least once a day.
  - **Chemical Safety:**
    - **Use:** Only chemicals in well-ventilated areas.
    - **Mixing:** Do not mix chemicals unless specified by directions.
    - **Spills:** Clean up chemical spills immediately to prevent hazards.

Emergency Preparedness

- **Emergency Plan:**
  - **Response:** Staff should know how to respond quickly if a fire breaks out.
  - **Evacuation:** Employees must be trained to evacuate the vehicle safely and lead customers to a safe distance from the MFV.
  - **Exit Routes:** Ensure staff knows all exit routes and procedures.
- **Power Shut Off:**
  - **Training:** Train staff on how to safely shut off propane and electrical power in emergencies.
  - **Practice:** Conduct regular drills to familiarize staff with emergency shutoff procedures.

Implementing these detection devices and training practices will enhance the safety of MFV operations, ensuring a swift and effective response to any potential hazards.